



Lewis Howles

< Versatile UI/UX Developer, Designer & Leader >

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I'm a passionate, versatile UI/UX Developer and Designer, with over **17 years** experience spanning UI Design, Front-end Development, Web Design, Graphic Design and, historically, Backend Development.

Championing user experience, developer experience, inclusivity, accessibility, communication, and consistency, I bring a unique view, attention to detail, and the ability to bridge teams. As a Designer and Front-end developer, I genuinely love mixing creativity with technical implementation and wearing both hats on any given day. With the ability to grasp the bigger picture, or zoom in to the smallest detail, I love working with a cross-functional team to help create powerful software, setting the standard that software—and websites—should be easy to use and accessible to as many people as possible.

Whether planning, designing or developing, I aim to be as well rounded as I can in order to make the best experiences possible, with the ability to advocate for the user, keep a level head, and to help guide decisions. I pride myself in my problem solving, attention to detail, efficiency, and my ability to communicate technical subjects to less technical people.

I was once described as the glue that brought the team together and I like to help my team whenever I can. I have extensive experience with team supervision and review, including designs, code, APIs, and usability. I also love to create libraries and tools, ensuring the highest standards and consistency for everyone to work from.

Preferred tools, software and frameworks

I include these to give an idea of my personality, and how I like to set myself up to get things done quickly and properly.

Vue.js	My preferred Front-end framework for rapid, scalable, testable development
Tailwind CSS	Atomic CSS framework, which works perfectly with frameworks like Vue and helps with consistency
Vite	Front-end tooling
Bun	A faster alternative to npm and pnpm
Vitest	A Vite-native Jest-compatible unit testing framework
Cypress	Integration and end-to-end testing tool
VS Code	A cross-platform, extendable, fast IDE-like editor
Sketch	macOS native, extendable, vector design platform
Notion	Powerful note-taking app, especially for teams
GitHub Desktop	Though it seems to lack Git-Flow support, it's actually a nice app to use
Paste	Clipboard history manager, making it easy to deal with lots of information at once
ForkLift	macOS Finder replacement and (S)FTP tool in one
Raycast	Spotlight / Alfred replacement with powerful extensibility
Hyper	Extensible, customisable Terminal alternative
Firefox	The plucky underdog, with, in my opinion, much better Dev Tools

I've also tried **Figma** in the past, and while it has some tools that Sketch doesn't, I found it much less intuitive and much less productive. I previously used Photoshop for web design, and have some familiarity with the Adobe suite from that time.

Finally, I have extensive experience with VS Code, Office, Notion, Jira, etc.

Key skills

- The ability to participate in the entire lifecycle of a product, from concept and design to testing and deployment.
- A strong understanding of web technologies, particularly HTML, CSS, and Javascript, but also user experience and accessibility, doing my best to ensure no-one is left behind. My passion for inclusive design fuels my drive to craft delightful user experiences.
- Great design sensibilities—and a desire to apply those to all things. Making things look good, but more importantly, making them easy to use, whatever the device. Extensive experience using Sketch on macOS, with a working knowledge of Figma (Sketch is much more intuitive to me, and I'm experienced in writing plugins for it).
- The ability to turn ideas and wishlists into requirements and a plan of action, differentiating must, should, and could.
- A strong sense of the importance of testing—from Unit to Integration to End-to-end. Eventually, you even come to enjoy it.
- Efficiency and automation are my thing. I frequently write helpful code to perform repetitive tasks, or come up with ways to allow common features to be implemented more and more quickly—ask me about Form Builder, Page Scaffold, or my component scaffold scripts.
- If efficiency and automation are my thing, so are attention to detail and problem solving. I pride myself in my ability to work out a problem, and to provide more than just an MVP every time.
- Excellent technical communication and writing skills, giving me the ability to communicate complex topics or requirements to team members, stakeholders, and customers at their level.
- Front-end developers know that it often feels like keeping on top of things is a full-time job in itself, and my eagerness to learn and keep up explains why I'm signed up to more newsletters than I can keep up with.
- I strive to be friendly and helpful, rather than dismissive, and I believe I have the ability to bring a team closer together and bring fun to the workplace—such as adding film references to designs or to code. But I can also work alone, as was often the case as a solo Front-end developer. I love to use to-do lists to keep me focused.
- A solid understanding of RESTful API design and integration, and OpenAPI specifications—including using Prism for initial development, and reviewing API specs with Backend teams to ensure they make sense for an end user both in terms of structure and documentation.
- Long-term use of Git for version control.
- Working knowledge of database design and decent SQL query skills.
- Experienced in working as part of an Agile team, using a mixture of Scrum and Kanban techniques.
- Experienced in leveraging AI tools to perform mundane tasks, such as generating fixtures, converting code between languages, etc.
- I have previously been a facilitator of Andy's Man Club, and have been visiting the group regularly since January 2024.



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Employment history

AppsAnywhere

- Creative and UI/UX Lead Aug 2023–Jun 2024
- UI Lead Sep 2019–Aug 2023

At AppsAnywhere, my goal was to help direct the shape of AppsAnywhere and all related products, harnessing the power of the software in a way that's accessible to all. I championed user experience, accessibility, efficiency and setting a high base standard, helping to take features through ideation, design, presentation, build and testing. Highlights include:

- Setting a new standard for quality and consistency—including creating a style guide for branding and a design system for UI design—and helping to set up best practices for design, code and testing, from shaping new processes and procedures, to setting the foundation for each of our Front-end projects.
- Creating an all-new design system, enabling much faster design for features and projects.
- Creating heavily-tested Javascript Helper and Vue.js Component libraries, as well as a UI Testing library to simplify both unit and integration tests; accelerating development further and ensuring consistency and confidence in the fundamentals. This was exemplified by my ability to keep up with three Backend developers, while often single-handedly covering both Design and Front-end development.
- Re-building the Portal of AppsAnywhere with my tech stack of choice—OpenAPI, Vue.js, Tailwind, Vitest, Cypress and Bun—as well as implementing extensive testing. Beyond removing tech debt, this allowed me to rocket-fuel our ability to iterate and add new features, allowed the implementation of translation to multiple languages for all UI text, including Arabic, reduced customer reported Front-end defects to near zero, and, working with an external auditor, took that Portal to full WCAG 2.0 AA compliance.
- Combining the new tech stack with the existing MVC PHP app to allow progressive improvements to the Admin panel of AppsAnywhere, allowing new features to be developed and tested in a more modern and resilient way, while not affecting the functionality of the existing jQuery-based Front-end (which I actually also built as a freelancer while at ISSL).
- Utilising Jira and Scrumban techniques—such as Daily Stand Ups, Sprint Planning, Sprint Retrospectives and Sprint Reviews—to track, plan, and co-ordinate work with the team and stakeholders.
- Presenting new features in our company-wide Sprint Reviews, explaining the purpose and benefits of features and updates while keeping things light for those that didn't need absolute detail.
- People-centred tasks such as helping our Support team when necessary, introducing AppsAnywhere to new staff and discussing its capabilities with existing staff, and talking to customers about their needs, including running workshops at User Days.

ISSL - Internet Solutions Services Limited

- Director Nov 2017–Sep 2019
- Studio Manager Mar 2014–Oct 2017
- Senior Web Designer Nov 2010–Mar 2014
- Web Designer Apr 2009–Nov 2010

My time at ISSL took me from Web Designer to Director and, through hard work and attention to detail, I expanded my own abilities and that of the company, improving our workflows and choosing the right tools to allow us to provide solutions to customers that weren't possible when I joined, as beautiful on the inside as they were on the outside. In the end, I oversaw Web Design and almost all ISSL projects. Highlights include:

- Using my technical communication skills to guide customers through the Web Design process, including requirements gathering, design, development, content management and SEO.
- Reacting quickly to changes in direction or requirements, giving the customer what they want without holding up the rest of the process.
- Extensive use of CMS, including creating and maintaining our website boilerplate, allowing a new site to be set up in minutes, ready for the development process.
- Creating features such as window-ready featured property displays.
- Developing an integration for our CMS of choice to allow our Estate Agent customers to utilise our in-house property search in a design-agnostic, flexible way, including features such as nearby amenities.
- Lead developer for Standout Property Manager, including Backend Development as well as Design and Front-end Development, working on both sides of the property management experience, designing ways to make property management easier and more effective for our customers.
- Developing Stand Out Property Websites, a set of powerful, customisable property search website templates for any estate or letting agents, no matter what property software they use. These website templates could be used to quickly create a CMS-powered website based from a hand-crafted template, with the most complete set of features we had ever offered, all while offering a same-day turnaround if necessary.

Education



BSc Computer Science, University of Sheffield
Second-class Honours, Upper Division

Fun fact

 I own ~60 pairs of trainers, and love lots of colour.